WEEK 10 / COMMUNITIES, CREATIVITY, AND PLAYER CULTURE

Modding, Private Servers, Preservation, and Fan Communities

Exploring fan-driven content and private servers.

This week, we explore fan-driven content creation through modding and the role of community-run and private servers in gaming.

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23 RESOURCES / 1 TOPIC

TOPIC 01

Modding and Community-Run Worlds

REQUIRED

Exploring and extending world cultures through video games

ARCHIVE | ~6 MIN

https://www.creativityculturecapital.org/blog/2021/09/13/exploring-and-extending-world-cultures-through-video-games/

This article advocates for video games as a powerful medium for cultural understanding and preservation, challenging the idea that they disconnect youth from their heritage. It highlights the collaborative development of Never Alone (Kisima Ingitchuna), a game created with the Alaska Native tribal organization, the Cook Inlet Tribal Council, to authentically share Indigenous culture and stories. The article discusses the game's success both commercially and as an educational tool.

Highlights:

Video games offer participatory and player-driven storytelling, allowing for deep immersion and exploration of diverse cultures and themes in an active rather than passive way.
Never Alone, developed with the Alaska Native community, successfully extended Indigenous culture by telling an oral story in the Inupiat language and including "Cultural Insights" (mini-documentary videos) unlocked through gameplay.
- The game achieved commercial success (over 4 million downloads and profitability) and significant educational impact, being used in classrooms globally and showcased in museums.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

Game Modding as Fast As Possible

YOUTUBE | ~6 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4BB1HfvSqAI&ab_channel=Techquickie

This video provides a quick overview of game modding, categorizing mods into four main types: content add-ons, gameplay mechanics tweaks/overhauls (including "unofficial patches"), graphical/art mods, and user interface/quality of life mods. It explains that mods can refresh older games by adding new content, altering mechanics, or improving visuals, acknowledging that while they can introduce bugs, mod organizers help manage them.

Highlights:

Mods can "breathe new life" into well-played games by adding new content (quests, areas), altering game mechanics (unofficial patches), enhancing graphics, and improving user interfaces.
The four basic categories of mods are content add-ons, gameplay mechanics tweaks/overhauls, graphical/art mods, and user interface/quality of life mods.
- Despite the potential for bugs and crashes from altering game code, mod organizers or loaders (e.g., for Minecraft, Skyrim) are available to assist users in installing and managing mods.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

A Trip Down Memory Lane: The Origins of Game Modding

YOUTUBE | ~17 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xIaYCcAViqk&ab_channel=Woahvi

This video delves into the history of game modding, tracing its roots back to the 1980s with early examples like Castle Wolfenstein. It highlights how the modding community evolved, particularly with id Software's Doom being the first game to offer built-in mod support. The video also discusses how many popular games, such as Team Fortress and Counter-Strike, originally started as mods, showcasing the significant impact of fan creations on the gaming industry.

Highlights:
- Early modding involved fans creating new content for games like Castle Wolfenstein (e.g., "Castle Smurfenstein") in the early 1980s, often through reverse-engineering game files.
- id Software's Doom (1993) revolutionized modding by being the first game to include built-in mod support through "wad" files, which made it easy for players to modify game assets and share their creations.
- Many successful, standalone games originated as mods, demonstrating modding's role as a "genesis of the Battle Royale craze" (e.g., DayZ Battle Royale leading to PUBG) and other major genres.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

The Importance of Game Modding

YOUTUBE | ~9 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3t2EEeUkQ58&ab_channel=FUNKe

This video emphasizes that modding is an "integral part of gaming today," responsible for extending game lifespans, fixing bugs, and fostering new development talent. It categorizes developers' approaches to

modding using an "alignment chart": Bethesda (chaotic good) for supporting it despite monetization, From Software (true neutral) for their cautious stance with ban risks, and Nintendo (lawful evil) for actively fighting modding and emulation. Valve is praised as "lawful good" for being founded on modding and providing extensive support and opportunities for modders.

Highlights:
- Developers' reactions to modding vary: Bethesda supports modding, even selling mods, which helps games like Skyrim remain relevant by relying on modders for bug fixes. Nintendo "notoriously fights" modding and emulation due to strict IP protection, leading to underground communities.
- Valve is highlighted as a pro-modding company, having been founded on games that started as mods (e.g., Dota, Team Fortress, Counter-Strike) and providing significant tools and platforms like the Steam Workshop that allow modders to create and even sell their creations.
- The video argues that "Today's modders are tomorrow's developers," emphasizing the role of modding as a critical learning ground for aspiring game creators and a means to "inspire creativity" in the industry.

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REQUIRED

A Lawyer Explains the PointCrow Takedowns and the Legality of Mods

YOUTUBE | ~25 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mo_AmQgSSqY&ab_channel=MoonChannel

In this video, a lawyer, Mooney, explains the legal perspective on game modding, using Nintendo's copyright strikes against YouTuber PointCrow as a case study. The video clarifies that most mods are considered copyright infringement because they are "derivative works" of the original game, and the "fair use" defense is often difficult to apply in this context. It emphasizes that copyright holders, especially large companies like Nintendo, fiercely protect their intellectual property.

Highlights:

Legally, virtually all mods are considered copyright infringement under US law because they are "derivative works" of the original game, and copyright holders have exclusive rights to create such works.
The "fair use" defense, which allows limited use of copyrighted material, is a litigation defense (used only in court) and is generally difficult to apply to game mods, especially those that extensively transform a game while retaining its core identity.
- Game content guidelines provided by companies (like Nintendo's) are described as "benevolent offerings" and "not a license agreement," meaning the company can unilaterally decide what content is acceptable and withdraw its toleration at any time.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

Modding Heaven: When Games Become Engines

YOUTUBE | ~41 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bmVsv15gjdg&ab_channel=Lufa

This video introduces the concept of "modding heaven," where a game becomes so moddable it functions like a game engine, allowing entirely new experiences or even games to be built upon its foundation. It identifies three key factors that determine a game's modability: developer support, the game's inherent nature (e.g., sandbox), and the passion of its community. Doom, Minecraft (Java Edition), and Skyrim are analyzed as prime examples that have reached this "modding heaven" status. I'm willing to forgive the mispronunciation of

“id software” because of the great information!

Highlights:

"Modding heaven" refers to games that are so extensively moddable they can act as a "template" or "engine" for creating completely new gaming experiences or "total conversion mods".
The three factors determining a game's modability are developer support (e.g., providing tools), the game's inherent nature (e.g., open-world suitability), and the passion of its player base.
- Examples: Doom achieved this through revolutionary built-in support ("wads") and community passion. Minecraft (Java Edition) did so through its sandbox nature and passionate community despite minimal official support. Skyrim reached it with strong developer support (Creation Kit) and an open-world design.

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REQUIRED

Rolling Your Own (from Pastplay: Teaching and Learning History with Technology)

BOOK EXCERPT | ~24 MIN

https://muse.jhu.edu/pub/166/oa_edited_volume/chapter/1127334

This academic chapter explores the use of modding commercial games, specifically Civilization IV, for educational purposes in history. The author recounts his unsuccessful attempt to impose a mod-based assignment in his online Roman history class due to the "creepy treehouse" phenomenon (forced, unnatural technology use). In contrast, he observes how genuine, self-organized learning about history occurs within online fan modding communities like Civfanatics, often "without teachers".

Highlights:
- Modding offers potential for historical education by allowing students to engage with complex historical scenarios, causality, and contingency (e.g., the Year of the Four Emperors in Civilization IV).
The author's experience demonstrates the "creepy treehouse" phenomenon, where forced or unnatural integration of technology in education can hinder engagement. Successful educational modding, he argues, should be student-led and emerge naturally from community interest.
Online fan communities can be vibrant spaces for self-organized learning, where members collaboratively explore and debate historical authenticity in their mods, providing a model for educators.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

Do Private Servers Benefit Or Harm MMORPGs?

ARTICLE | ~8 MIN

https://mmos.com/editorials/do-private-servers-benefit-or-harm-mmorpgs

This opinion piece argues that private servers, while legally precarious, often benefit MMORPGs by preserving older game experiences, fostering dedicated communities, and generating continued interest in intellectual properties. The author shares personal anecdotes about playing on private Ragnarok Online servers and discusses instances where official developers have either tolerated or formally sanctioned fan projects.

Highlights:

Private servers often exist because players desire a "return to glory days" or a specific gameplay experience (e.g., different experience rates, level caps) that official servers no longer provide or have diverged from (e.g., "vanilla World of Warcraft").

They are crucial for resurrecting and preserving games that are no longer officially supported, serving as the only means to play deceased MMORPGs like Star Wars Galaxies.

- The author argues that private servers often bolster interest in the original IP, acting as a form of "additional advertising" and "influencer support," even if some (especially profit-driven ones) face legal action from publishers.

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REQUIRED

87% Missing: the Disappearance of Classic Video Games

BLOG POST | ~4 MIN

https://gamehistory.org/87percent/

Published by the Video Game History Foundation in 2023, this article explains research finding that 87% of classic games released in the United States were no longer commercially available. It discusses the consequences for historians, researchers, and players, as well as the copyright restrictions facing preservation institutions.

Includes links to a more detailed blog post (https://gamehistory.org/study-explainer) and the study itself (https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.8161056).

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.
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REQUIRED

The VGHF Library opens in early access

BLOG POST | ~9 MIN

https://gamehistory.org/vghf-library-launch/

Introduces the Video Game History Foundation's digital library, launched in January 2025. The archive includes game magazines, development documents, promotional materials, and other historical artifacts. It demonstrates that preserving gaming history involves much more than preserving playable software.

Includes a link to the archive (https://library.gamehistory.org/) and a 12-minute video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6Tysm_Wf60Q).

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REQUIRED

Video Game Play Capture Project

ARTICLE | ~3 MIN

https://www.museumofplay.org/collections/icheg/video-game-play-capture-project/

The Video Game Play Capture Project, launched by the International Center for the History of Electronic Games, addresses the critical challenge of preserving video game history for future generations. By recording gameplay directly from original hardware systems, the initiative captures the authentic experience of diverse titles-ranging from classic consoles to defunct online multiplayer servers-much more effectively than simple photographs or software emulators. Furthermore, the museum collaborates with prominent external institutions and archives to advance data migration techniques and ensure that interactive entertainment remains accessible to on-site researchers.

Also learn more about the International Center for the History of Electronic Games (https://www.museumofplay.org/collections/icheg/) at The Strong National Museum of Play (https://www.museumofplay.org/).

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REQUIRED

With a near-unprecedented official license for its fan server, one of PC gaming's great MMOs has a vibrant future: 'Let it be shouted far and wide: City of Heroes lives again'

ARTICLE | ~12 MIN

https://www.pcgamer.com/games/mmo/with-a-near-unprecedented-official-license-for-its-fan-server-one-of-pc-gamings-great-mmos-has-a-vibrant-future-let-it-be-shouted-far-and-wide-city-of-heroes-lives-again/

This article celebrates the "near-unprecedented" official license granted by NCSoft to City of Heroes: Homecoming, a fan-run private server for the defunct MMO City of Heroes. It details the years of meticulous work and professional standards maintained by the volunteer Homecoming team, which ultimately convinced NCSoft to sanction the server, allowing the beloved game to be resurrected for its passionate community without legal risk.

Highlights:
- NCSoft granted an official, non-commercial license to the fan-run City of Heroes: Homecoming server, an "extraordinary arrangement" that allows the previously shut-down MMO to continue operating legitimately for its loyal fanbase.
- The success was largely due to the professionalism and diligence of the volunteer Homecoming team, which maintained high technical and security standards, as well as player support and moderation teams, instilling confidence in NCSoft.
- This agreement sets a positive example for other MMO owners by demonstrating a way to support and empower lost communities, ensuring the longevity of games that have passionate fan bases even after official support ends.

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REQUIRED

EverQuest fan project given blessing by Daybreak

ARTICLE | ~2 MIN

https://www.pcgamer.com/everquest-fan-project-given-blessing-by-daybreak/

This news article reports on the significant development of Daybreak Game Company (formerly Sony Online Entertainment) officially recognizing and sanctioning Project 1999, a not-for-profit fan-operated emulation of the original EverQuest. This landmark agreement ensures the project's legal viability and allows it to continue providing an authentic classic EverQuest experience to players who own the Titanium Edition of the game.

Highlights:
- Daybreak Game Company formally recognized Project 1999, a fan-run EverQuest emulation, granting it an official written agreement that allows it to continue without legal repercussions.
  This sanctioning set a precedent for collaboration between publishers and fan communities, rather than issuing cease and desist orders.
  The agreement established specific guidelines for Project 1999, ensuring its operation aligns with Daybreak's expectations while preserving the classic game experience.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

These Steam Games Become GOD-TIER With Mods

YOUTUBE | ~20 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=W8BlgBo15kg&ab_channel=thebluecrusader

This video highlights how player-created modifications (mods) significantly enhance various PC games, making them more engaging and extending their longevity. It showcases how mods can completely transform game experiences, from overhauling graphics and adding vast amounts of new content to introducing unique gameplay mechanics or turning a game into an entirely different genre. The source emphasizes the diverse impact of modding communities, illustrating how their creativity provides endless possibilities for customization, replayability, and maintaining the freshness of even classic titles. Several specific game titles are featured, including Terraria, Left 4 Dead 2, Garry's Mod, Skyrim, multiple Grand Theft Auto games, STALKER, Half Life 2, and several others.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Top 10 Game Mods You NEED To Try

YOUTUBE | ~13 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eI6pgLot1-U&ab_channel=LevelCapGaming

This source presents a curated list of top PC game mods, highlighting the "added value that mods bring" to the gaming world. It showcases the diversity of mods, including standalone overhauls that don't require the base game (Stalker Anomaly), total conversions that change game genres (Galactic Contention for Squad), visual enhancements, quality-of-life improvements, and mods that provide ongoing server support for games after official shutdowns.

Highlights:

Some extensive mods, such as Stalker Anomaly and its Gamma build, are free, standalone experiences that

do not require owning the original game to play.
Mods can provide total conversion experiences, transforming games into entirely new genres (e.g., Squad becoming a Star Wars milsim with Galactic Contention) or adapting them for new technologies (e.g., Half-Life 2 into VR).
- Modding communities play a crucial role in extending a game's lifespan and providing server support for titles whose official servers may shut down (e.g., Venice Unleashed for Battlefield 3, Project Rome for Bad Company 2).

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EXPLORE FURTHER

WickedWhims: A Conversation about Adult Content Creation and Responsible Adult Mods Design - Aurélie Petit

ARTICLE | ~42 MIN

https://tag-milieux.ca/tag-articles/wickedwhims

This interview with TURBODRIVER, the creator of the popular Sims 4 WickedWhims mod, explores the complex world of adult content creation within game modding. It delves into the motivations for creating such content, the community-driven development process (especially without official modding tools), the challenges of monetization through platforms like Patreon, and the ethical considerations involved in designing and moderating adult-themed mods.

Highlights:
- The Sims 4 modding community, particularly for adult content like WickedWhims, relies heavily on custom, community-made software and tools due to the lack of official developer-provided modding kits.
- Modders can become full-time professionals through community support, as evidenced by TURBODRIVER monetizing WickedWhims via Patreon, attracting a massive player base of around 300,000 daily users.
- The creator actively engages in responsible design and moderation, aiming for "sex positivity" while setting ethical lines (e.g., against content involving children or animals) and fostering a curated community platform (WickedCC) to feature "clean" adult content creators.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Play/explore popular mods or private servers

ACTIVITY

CurseForge, Google, and Bing are good places to start looking for mods or private servers for games you already own and play. Be sure to follow all installation instructions carefully, and only download mods from reputable sources to avoid malware. Or, look for playthroughs on YouTube if you don't want to install anything yourself.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Flashpoint Archive

WEB SITE

https://flashpointarchive.org/

A community-driven effort to preserve browser games and interactive media, particularly those threatened by the disappearance of Flash and other obsolete web technologies. This offers an example of volunteers organizing to save an important part of gaming history.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Fan-Translations and ROM Hacking Interviews

WEB SITE

https://www.gamingalexandria.com/wp/2023/07/fan-translations-and-rom-hacking-interviews-by-john-szczepaniak/

Gaming Alexandria preserved interviews originally conducted in 2006 with members of the ROM-hacking and fan-translation community. The materials provide a look at early fan culture and how enthusiasts made games more accessible across language barriers.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Club Penguin: Gone But Not Forgotten

YOUTUBE | ~37 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aR2EK9f4X4E&ab_channel=Burback

This video offers a nostalgic look at the popular children's MMO Club Penguin, detailing its creation, gameplay features, and eventual shutdown by Disney. It highlights the game's focus on child safety and imaginative play, its membership-based monetization, and the subsequent emergence of fan-run private servers, which faced legal challenges from Disney.

Highlights:
- Club Penguin was intentionally designed as a safe, ad-free online social space for kids, with a strong emphasis on moderation and fostering imaginative play, even incorporating community jokes and rumors into game updates.
  The game operated on a \$5.95/month membership model that unlocked most customization options and exclusive content, leading to a "class system" among child players based on who could afford it.
  After Disney shut down the official servers in 2017, fan-run private servers emerged to preserve the game, gaining massive popularity (e.g., Club Penguin Rewritten reaching 30,000 sign-ups daily); however, attempts to monetize these servers led to legal action and arrests for copyright infringement.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

6 Major Differences Between Classic WoW & Turtle WoW

ARTICLE | ~15 MIN

https://gamerant.com/major-differences-classic-wow-turtle-wow-changes-world-of-warcraft-classic-plus-private-server/

This article describes Turtle WoW, a fan-made World of Warcraft private server designed as a "Classic WoW Plus" experience. It outlines six significant differences between Turtle WoW and the original Classic WoW, ranging from minor updates to massive content additions and gameplay overhauls.

Highlights:
- Turtle WoW adds new playable races, High Elves for the Alliance and Goblins for the Horde, each with unique starting zones and racial bonuses, designed to fit the vanilla WoW aesthetic.
  The private server introduces dozens of new zones and over a thousand new quests across Azeroth, including areas cut from the original game like Mount Hyjal and Gilneas, complete with their own environments, soundtracks, and questlines.
  Turtle WoW incorporates features from later WoW expansions, such as Transmogrification and Jewelcrafting, adapted with unique mechanics that distinguish them from their retail versions.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Stop Killing Games

WEB SITE

https://www.stopkillinggames.com/

I've provided a few links related to the Stop Killing Games movement.

From site: "Stop Killing Games" is a consumer movement started to challenge the legality of publishers destroying video games they have sold to customers. An increasing number of video games are sold effectively as goods \- with no stated expiration date \- but designed to be completely unplayable as soon as support from the publisher ends. This practice is a form of planned obsolescence and is not only detrimental to customers, but makes preservation effectively impossible. Furthermore, the legality of this practice is largely untested in many countries.

These links relate to bills in the European Union and State of California related to the movement:

YouTube: Stop Killing Games Fell at the Last Hurdle (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EAQVe6nk1GM) (\~16 min)
YouTube: Stop Killing Games Was Doomed. Now It Can't Be Stopped (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ebPmXqIMsGs) (\~18 min) (this video provides some history of the European Union bill related to the movement and this news story provides more up to date information (https://tech-insider.org/stop-killing-games-eu-commission-2026/))

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EXPLORE FURTHER

One QR Code Destroyed The 3DS Forever

YOUTUBE | ~27 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_zuuVwUPKac

This final video is slightly off-topic, but somewhat related. I came across it recently and wished I had found and shared it when we were discussing portable gaming, but since it relates to hacking game platforms I figured I could share it when we discuss game modding since some game modding does involve hacking. It recounts how the Nintendo 3DS, a handheld console engineered with unprecedented security features, was ultimately compromised by a single programming oversight. Despite having a complex architecture designed to be mathematically unhackable, the system fell to a "homebrew" exploit discovered within an obscure, low-budget title called Cubic Ninja. A French hacker exploited a stack buffer overflow in the game's QR code level-sharing feature to bypass the console's digital defenses. This initial breach triggered a years-long cat-and-mouse game between Nintendo and the hacking community, leading to the discovery of unpatchable flaws in the system's hardware and boot code. The narrative highlights a fundamental law of cybersecurity: a fortress is only as secure as its most vulnerable piece of internal software. Ultimately, this history influenced Nintendo to adopt a more resilient security philosophy for its subsequent hardware, the Nintendo Switch.

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